Turkey Branch Watershed Digital Twin

Model description, data, calibration and uncertainty

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Abstract

The Turkey Branch digital twin forecasts streamflow, stage, soil moisture and groundwater in the Turkey Branch watershed (Montgomery County, Maryland; 7.1 km^2 above USGS gage 01647850) for the next seven days, every six hours, with a 95 % uncertainty band. It runs a physically based, semi-distributed model built in the open-source OpenHydroQual (OHQ) framework (Massoudieh et al., 2023) with 19 sub-catchments of 0.15 km^2 to 0.76 km^2. Each sub-catchment represents its connected impervious and pervious land, three soil layers and an unconfined aquifer; eight drain to open channels whose sections are measured from 1 m lidar, eleven through streets and storm sewers sized from the county and state storm-drain inventories, and three stormwater ponds are represented. Ten watershed-wide parameters were estimated by Bayesian inference (Markov chain Monte Carlo) from four years of discharge and two years of stage at the gage; the twin runs the most probable parameter set and 200 sets drawn from the posterior distribution, whose spread gives the uncertainty band. Tested on four further years that were not used in calibration, the model reproduces the logarithm of flow with a Nash–Sutcliffe efficiency of 0.83 and stage with 0.78. This document describes the model, its data, its calibration and the validation results.

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1 What the twin does

Every six hours the twin

1. updates its rainfall with NOAA's Multi-Radar/Multi-Sensor (MRMS) radar–gauge precipitation analysis (hourly, 1 km, about one hour behind real time) and its reference evapotranspiration with gridMET, followed by the most recent days of Open-Meteo;
2. advances the model from its last saved state to the present (the *analysis*);
3. runs the model seven days ahead from that state with the Open-Meteo hourly precipitation and reference-evapotranspiration forecasts (the *forecast*);
4. repeats both steps for 200 parameter sets drawn from the calibration's posterior distribution, each from its own saved state, and takes the 2.5 and 97.5 percentiles of their results at every time (the *95 % band*);
5. publishes the results: maps of each model element, time series of every variable in every sub-catchment with its band, and model versus USGS real-time flow and stage at the gage.

The model state is carried from cycle to cycle, so the twin keeps a continuous memory of soil moisture and groundwater. It does not assimilate observations: the model is not adjusted to match the gage, which makes the comparison with the gage shown in the viewer an ongoing, independent check.

What the band means. The band shows how uncertain the model's output is because its parameters are only known within a range: it is the spread of 200 equally plausible models. It does not include the error of the model structure or of the rainfall, and in particular not the error of the rainfall forecast; observed flows therefore fall outside it more often than 5 % of the time (Section 7.1). In the viewer it is shown when the "95 % intervals" box is checked.

2 The watershed

Turkey Branch is a tributary of Rock Creek in the Maryland Piedmont (Aspen Hill and Rockville area). Above the USGS gage near Rockville (01647850) it drains 7.1 km^2. The basin is suburban: 39 % of it is impervious (roads 8.5 %, buildings 11.8 %, other paved areas 14.4 %, tree canopy over pavement 4.8 %), 38 % turf and 17 % forest. Only 6.4 km of stream is mapped in it; much of the drainage runs through 55 km of storm pipes. Montgomery County restored the main stem along the Matthew Henson Trail in about 2006–2009 and has since built or retrofitted several stormwater ponds; the USGS record starts in November 2006, so the calibration and validation years describe the restored channel. There are no combined sewers or reservoirs.

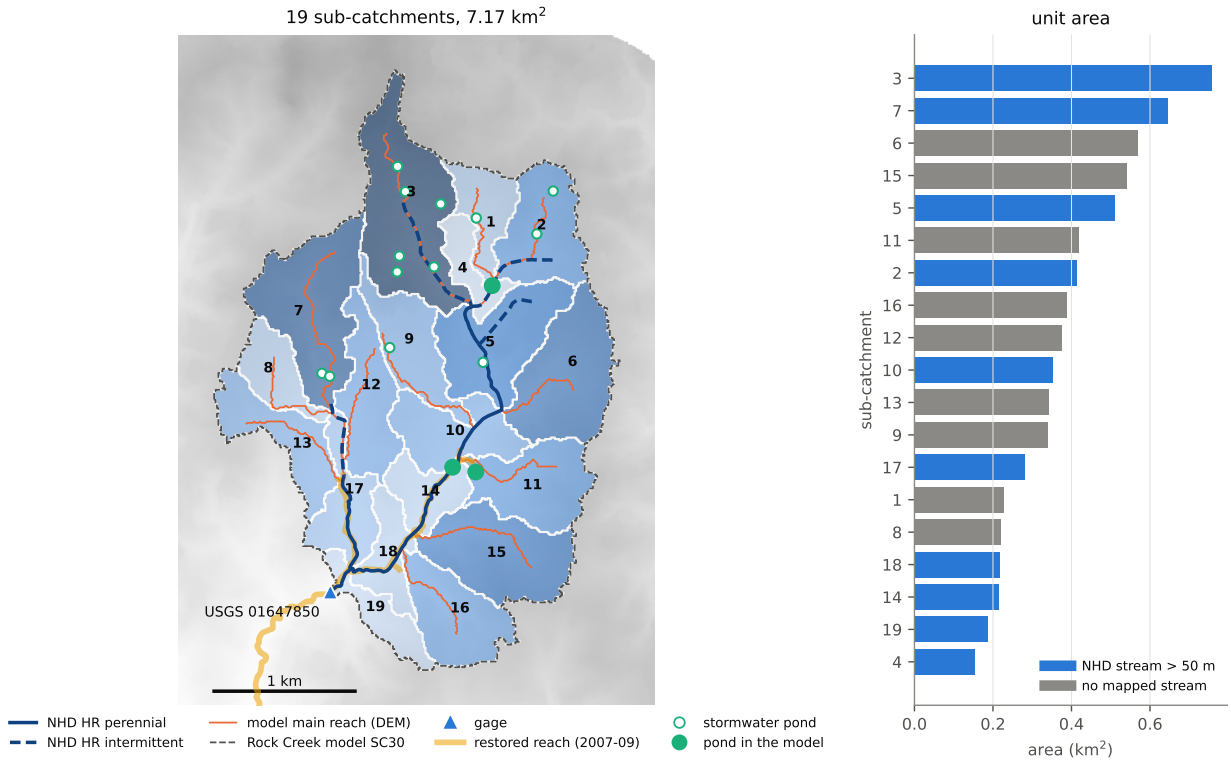


Figure 1: The 19 sub-catchments with their main flow paths, the mapped (NHDPlus HR) streams, the restored reach and the stormwater ponds; right: sub-catchment areas (grey: less than 50 m of mapped stream).

3 Model structure

3.1 Sub-catchments

The watershed is delineated from the USGS 3DEP 10 m elevation model, with the NHDPlus High Resolution flowlines burned in, into 19 sub-catchments whose outlets are the gage and the main confluences (Fig. 1). Each sub-catchment drains to one segment. Bed elevations come from a monotone profile carved through the elevation model, which passes road embankments and culverts (Fig. 2).

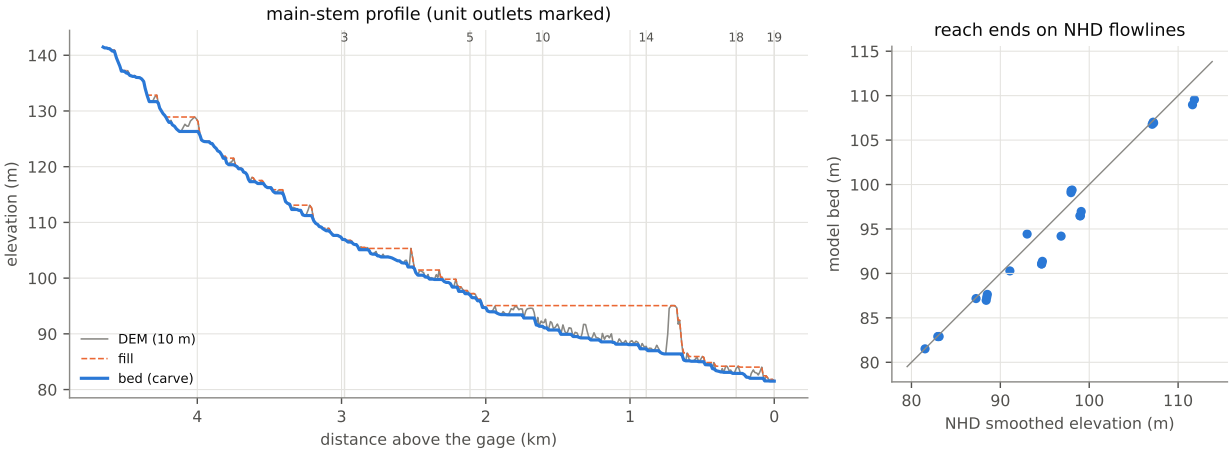


Figure 2: Main-stem longitudinal profile: elevation model, filled profile and model bed (carved).

3.2 The hydrologic response unit

Each sub-catchment is one *Urban HRU*, a composite element of OHQ (Fig. 3):

- an **impervious surface** — the *directly connected* impervious area (roofs, roads and parking areas that drain to a storm sewer or the stream) — that drains through an internal impervious reach to the unit's channel or street;
- a **pervious surface** — lawns, forest and the impervious surfaces that drain onto them — that drains through an internal pervious reach;
- three **soil layers** below the pervious surface, 0.5, 1 and 2 m thick, with their own hydraulic properties;
- an **unconfined aquifer** below the whole unit that receives recharge from the soil, discharges to the unit's channel or storm sewer (baseflow) and exchanges groundwater with the neighbouring units.

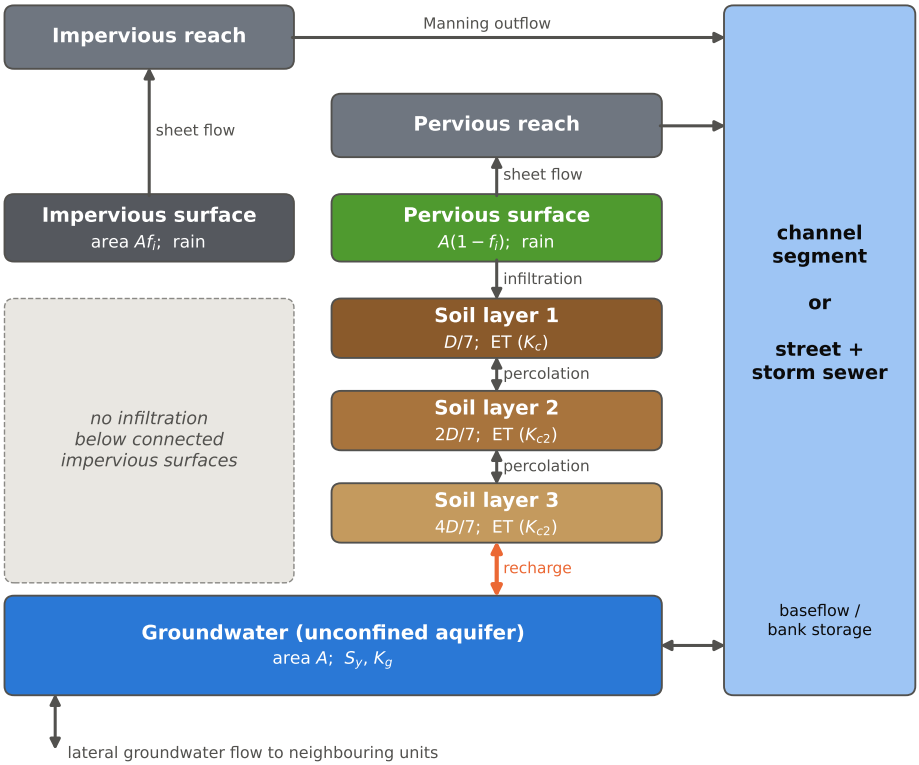


Figure 3: Structure of one sub-catchment (Urban HRU): storages (boxes) and fluxes (arrows; double arrows can flow both ways). A: area; f_i: connected impervious fraction; $D = 3.5\,\mathrm{m}$: soil depth.

3.3 Open channels and the gage section

Eight sub-catchments drain to open channels: the main stem from unit 4 down, the western tributary and one unmapped channel. Their cross-sections are measured on lidar transects every 20 m: a power-law main channel, $A = aY^m$, up to the bank height and a widening section above it (Fig. 5). The urban channels are two to three times wider than the rural Maryland Piedmont bank-full relations (McCandless and Everett, 2002) would give, which is why measured sections are used (Fig. 4). At the gage a short *gage segment* has a section fitted to the continuous record of simultaneous discharge and gage height under the current USGS rating (Fig. 6); its depth above the zero-flow control is directly comparable to the USGS stage.

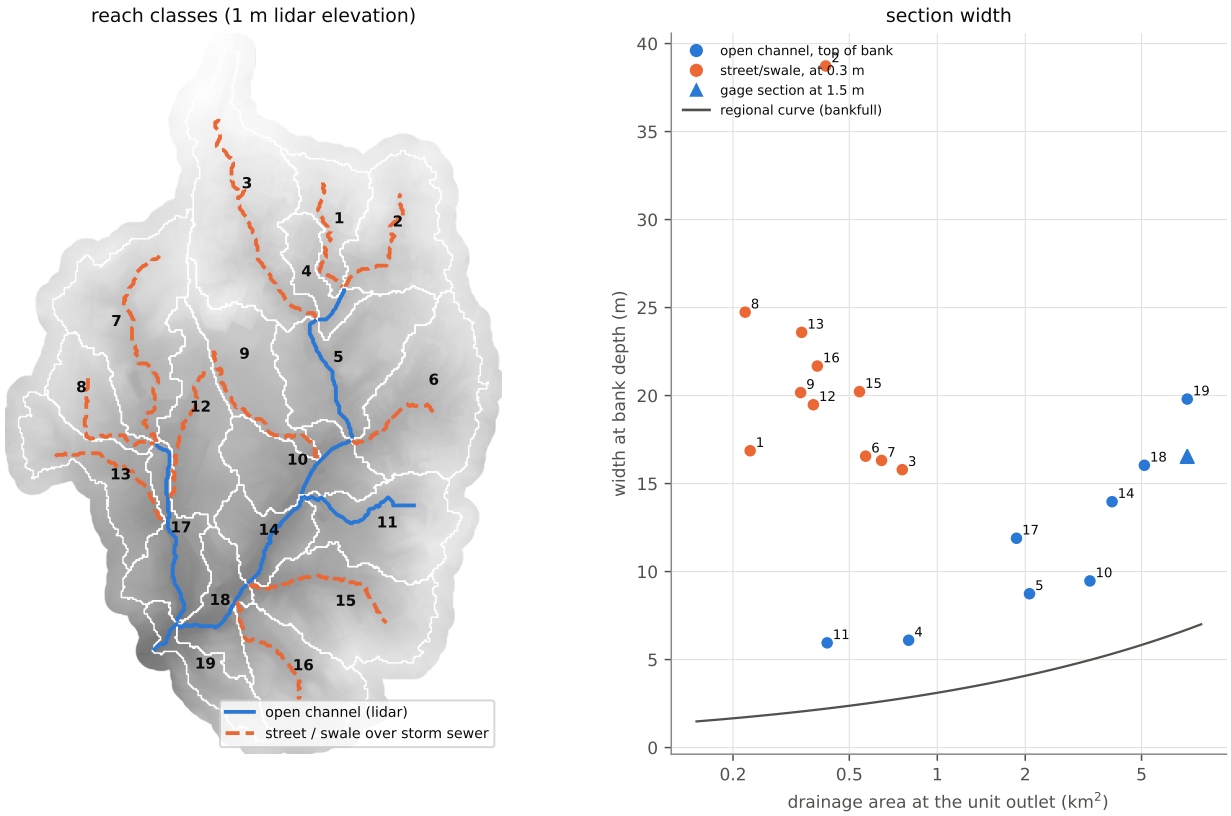


Figure 4: Left: open channels and piped units from the lidar transects. Right: channel width at bank height against drainage area, with the rural regional curve.

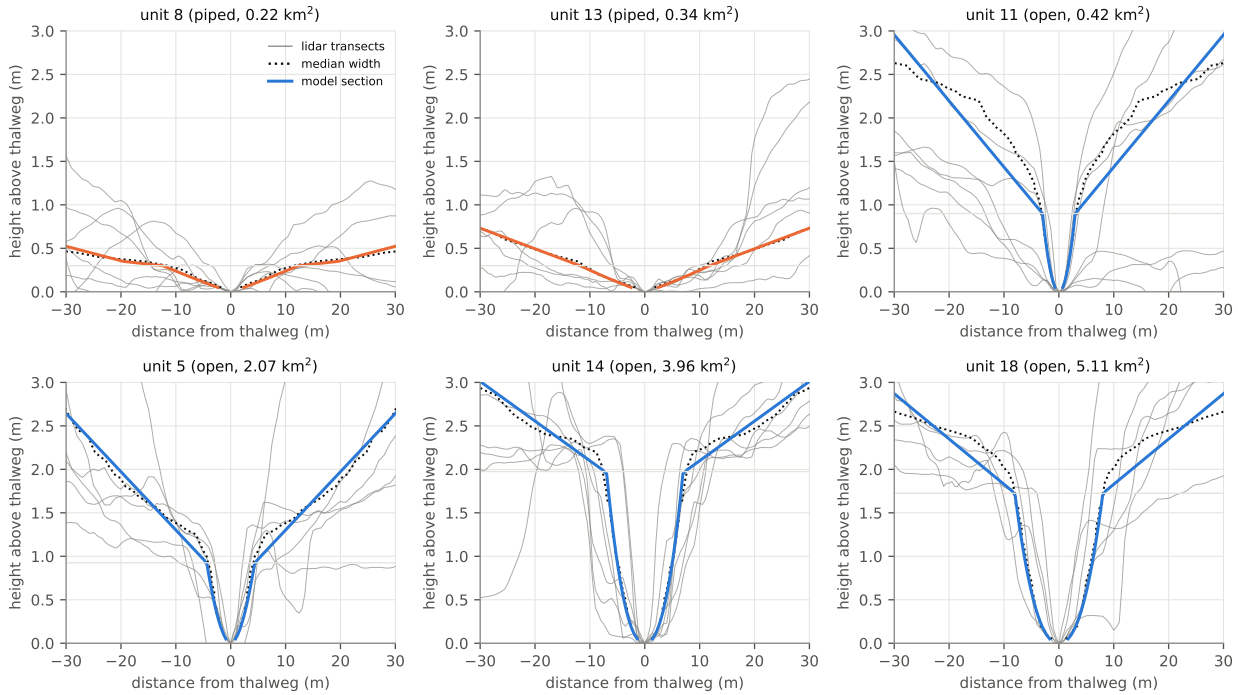


Figure 5: Lidar transects (grey), their median width (dotted) and the model section for two streets or swales and four open channels.

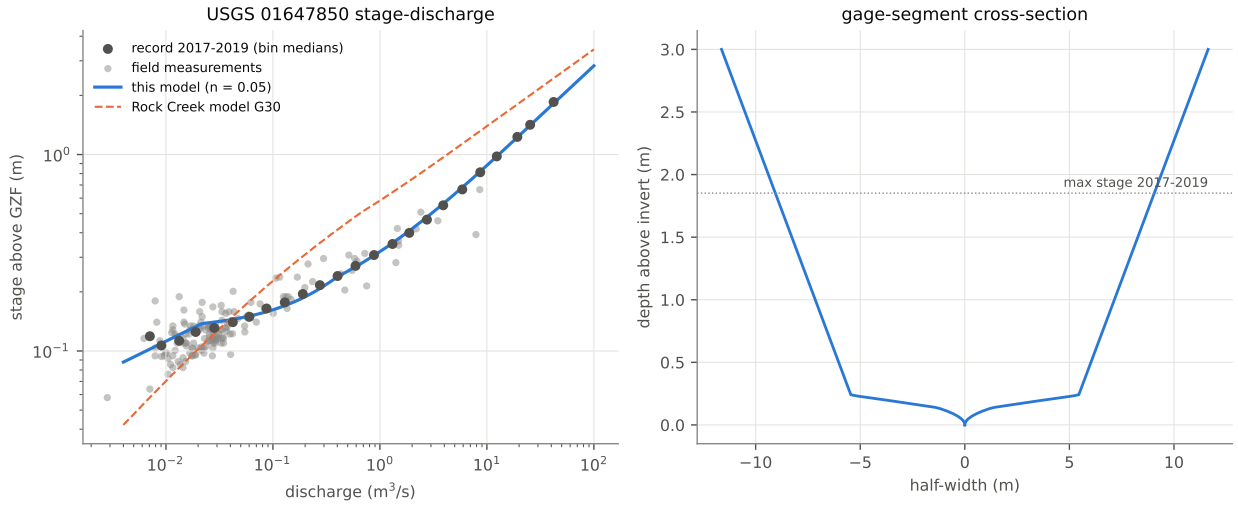


Figure 6: Stage against discharge at USGS 01647850 and the fitted gage section.

3.4 Streets and storm sewers

The other eleven sub-catchments have no channel: their surface flow path is a street or swale over a storm sewer. Each is represented by *dual drainage* (Fig. 9): runoff reaches the street segment, enters the sewer through the unit's inlets (lumped; weir or orifice flow, whichever is smaller), passes a catch basin that holds the unit's manholes and inlet boxes, and flows in the sewer to its outfall on the receiving channel or into the next sewer; what the inlets or the sewer cannot take continues

over the street. Where the sewer and the street are full, water spreads over the unit at the catch basin and drains back as the flood recedes. Sewer diameters are the recorded trunk sizes where the Montgomery County and State Highway Administration inventories give them, and otherwise follow a relation between pipe size and contributing area fitted to the 395 pipes of known size (Fig. 7); the fitted sizes are scaled by a calibrated multiplier. The groundwater of a piped unit discharges into its sewer.

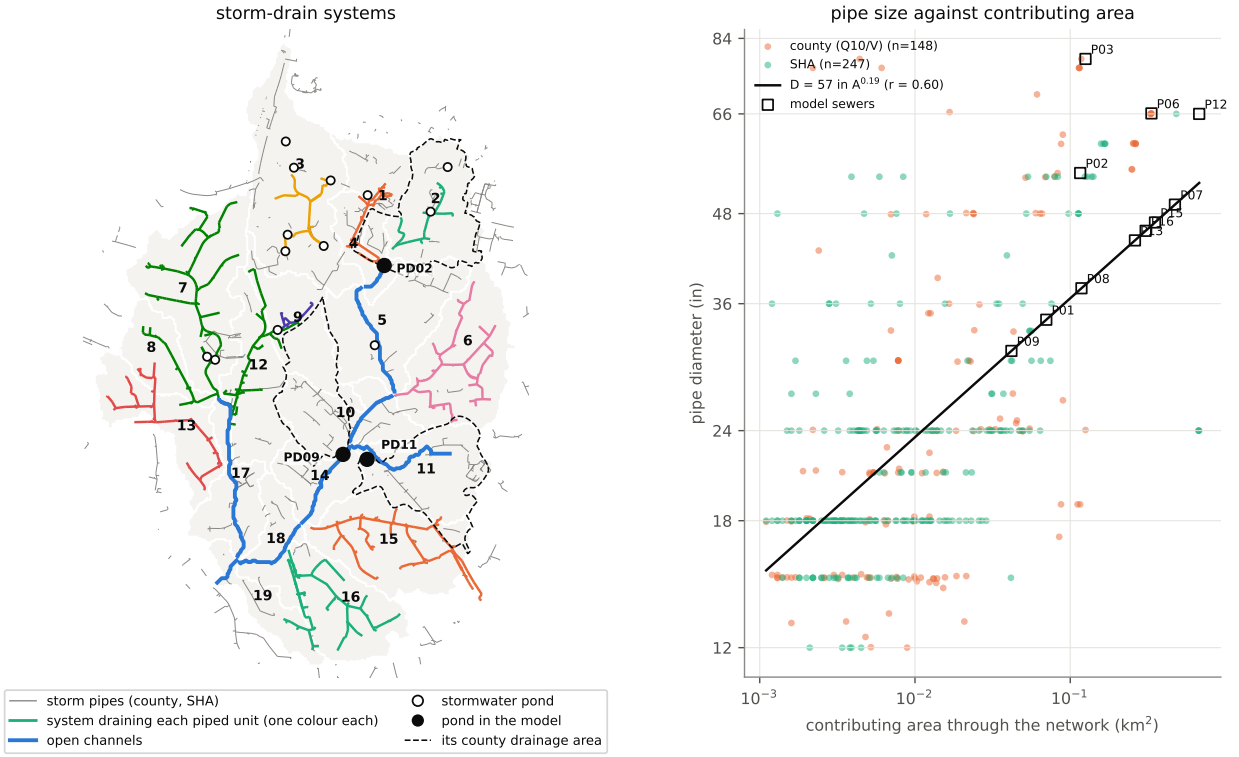


Figure 7: Left: storm pipes and the system that drains each piped unit; open channels in blue. Right: pipe diameter against contributing area, the fitted relation and the model sewers.

3.5 Stormwater ponds

Of the 16 stormwater ponds in the county's facility inventory, the three largest that each receive essentially one sub-catchment's outflow are represented: Peppertree (unit 2) and the two Matthew Henson ponds (units 9 and 11). Their stage–storage curves come from the 1 m lidar; their outlets (an extended-detention weir, a riser and an emergency spillway) follow Maryland design practice, since no as-built data were available (Fig. 8).

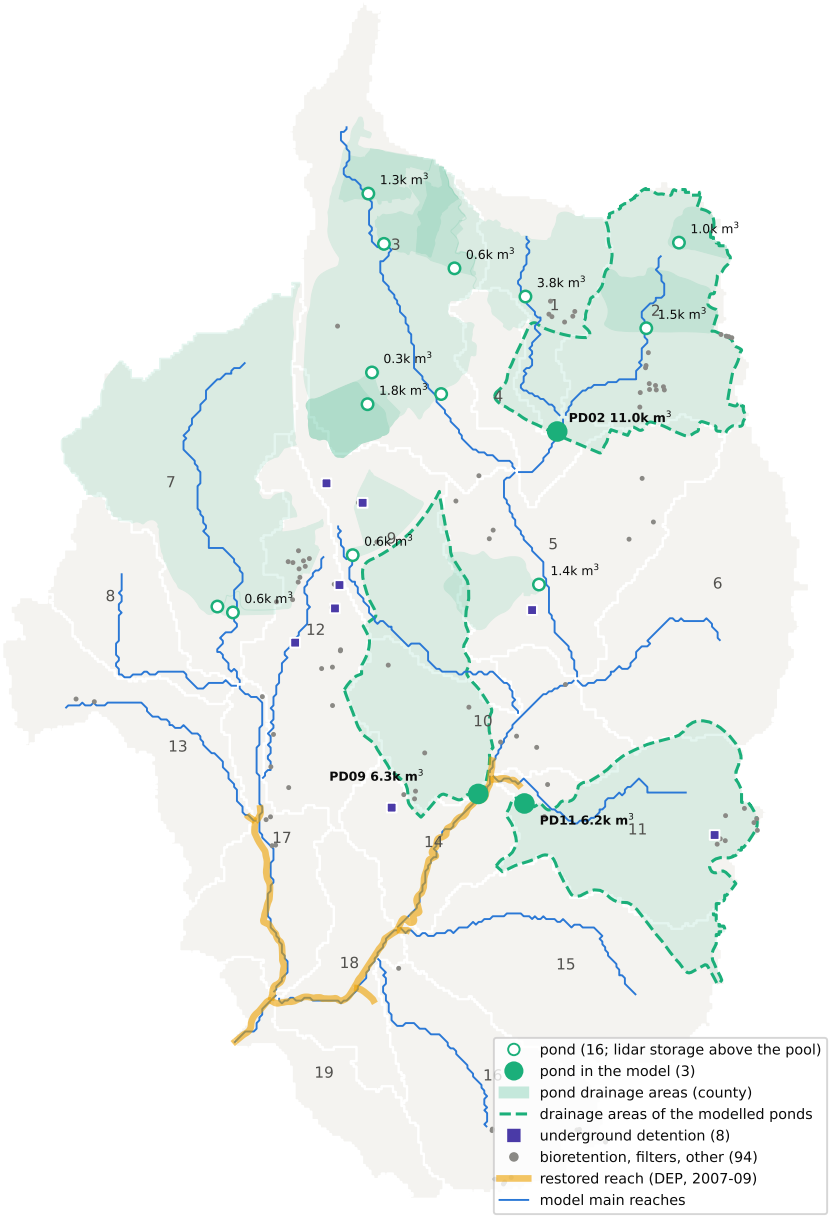


Figure 8: Stormwater facilities in the county inventory, the pond drainage areas (the three ponds in the model dashed and filled) and the restored reach.

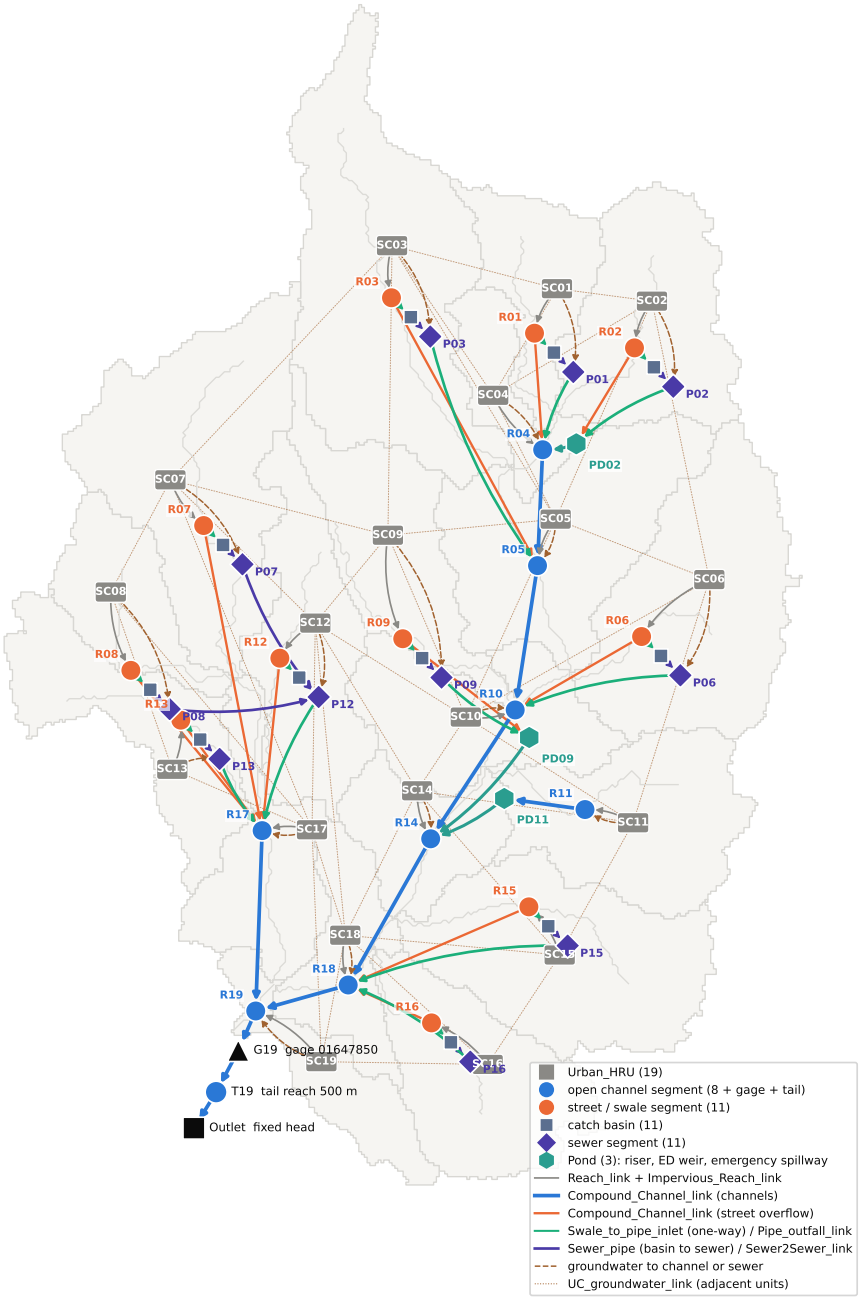


Figure 9: The whole model: sub-catchments (grey), open channels (blue), streets and swales (orange), sewers (purple), ponds (green), the gage segment, a tail reach and the outlet, with their surface, channel, inlet, outfall, groundwater and lateral groundwater connections.

4 Governing equations

OpenHydroQual represents a system as a network of storage elements (blocks) connected by flux elements (links), each defined by user-editable expressions, and solves the resulting equations to-

gether (Massoudieh et al., 2023; the equations of the standard components are given in Massoudieh and Shakouri, 2025). It solves a water balance for every storage element (surface, internal reach, soil layer, aquifer, channel, street, sewer, catch basin, pond),

$$\frac{dV_j}{dt} = \sum_{k \in \mathrm{in}(j)} Q_k - \sum_{k \in \mathrm{out}(j)} Q_k + P_j - E_j, \tag{1}$$

where V_j is the stored volume, Q_k the flows of the links that enter and leave it, P_j rainfall and E_j evapotranspiration. Lengths are in metres and time in days.

Surface runoff. Water ponded on a surface above its depression storage d_s runs off as sheet flow, $Q_s = (W/n_s)\, S^{1/2}\, (d - d_s)_+^{5/3}$, with overland-flow width W, slope S and Manning coefficient n_s.

Reaches, channels and streets. Flow between segments follows Manning's equation driven by the difference in water-surface elevation, $Q = \bar{n}^{-1} A_u R^{2/3} \big((h_1 - h_2)/\bar{L}\big)^{1/2}$, so backwater and flow reversal are represented.

Inlets, sewers and outfalls. Inlet flow is the smaller of the weir flow $C_w P\, d^{3/2}$ and the orifice flow $C_o A_o \sqrt{2g\,\Delta h}$ (HEC-22), with curb-opening length P and opening A_o of the unit's inlets. Sewers carry Manning flow in a circular section and surcharge when full; outfalls discharge with the sewer's flowing area and are free above the tailwater.

Soil water. Each soil layer follows the van Genuchten–Mualem relations,

$$S_e = \frac{\theta - \theta_r}{\theta_s - \theta_r}, \quad \psi = -\frac{1}{\alpha}\left(S_e^{-1/m} - 1\right)^{1/n}, \quad k_r = \left[1 - \left(1 - S_e^{1/m}\right)^{m}\right]^2, \quad m = 1 - \tfrac{1}{n}, \tag{2}$$

with total head $h = z + \psi$. Infiltration into the top layer is Darcy flow over half its thickness and percolation between layers is $Q = A\, K_s\, k_r(S_e)\, (h_i - h_j)/\bar{d}$, upward when the lower layer has the higher head.

Evapotranspiration. Each soil layer loses $E = K_c\, E_0(t)\, A\, \theta/\theta_s$, where E_0 is the reference (grass) evapotranspiration and K_c a crop coefficient, one for the top layer and one for the two deeper layers.

Recharge and groundwater. The bottom soil layer drains to the aquifer through its unsaturated conductivity, and receives water from it when the water table is higher. The water table follows from storage and specific yield S_y, $h_g = z_b + V/(S_y A)$; groundwater moves between neighbouring units by Darcy's law, $Q = \bar{K}\, \bar{b}\, W\, (h_1 - h_2)/L$, with the shared boundary length W and centroid distance L, and lateral outflow tapers to zero as a cell approaches the depth of its stream bed.

Baseflow. The aquifer exchanges water with the channel or sewer, $Q_b = K_b\, A_b\, (h_g - h_c)/L_b$, with bank area A_b (twice the reach length times 5 m) and path length L_b (half the inverse drainage density).

Ponds. Storage $S = \alpha d^{\beta}$ from the lidar; the riser discharges the lesser of the weir and the barrel capacity, the emergency spillway is a broad-crested weir.

Numerical solution. The equations of all 199 storages are solved together with an implicit (backward Euler) scheme and Newton iterations, with an adaptive time step of 43 s to about 7 minutes. For speed the model is compiled into C++ by the OHQ code generator, which reproduces the interpreter's solution; four years take about one minute on one processor core.

5 Data

All inputs are public (Table 1).

Table 1: Data sources.

Model input	Source
Terrain, drainage network	USGS 3DEP 10 m DEM and 1 m lidar (MD Central 2024); NHDPlus High Resolution
Land cover, imperviousness	Chesapeake Conservancy 1 m land use/land cover
Connected impervious area	Sutherland (2000) relation
Soils	NRCS SSURGO; van Genuchten parameters from Rosetta3
Channels	1 m lidar transects; USGS continuous discharge and gage-height record
Storm sewers, inlets	Montgomery County and Maryland SHA storm-drain inventories
Stormwater ponds, restoration	Montgomery County DEP stormwater-facility inventory and project database; 1 m lidar
Rainfall (calibration, validation)	NOAA Analysis of Record for Calibration (AORC), hourly, 1 km
Rainfall (operational)	NOAA MRMS multi-sensor QPE (hourly, 1 km); Open-Meteo forecast
Reference ET	gridMET (daily, 4 km); Open-Meteo FAO-56 reference ET (recent days and forecast)
Discharge and stage	USGS National Water Information System, gage 01647850

Land-cover fractions of each sub-catchment come from the 1 m Chesapeake land cover; total impervious area is converted to directly connected impervious area with the "average" Sutherland relation $\mathrm{DCIA} = 0.1\,\mathrm{TIA}^{1.5}$ (in percent; 25 % for the basin), which the calibration then scales watershed-wide. Soil hydraulic properties of the three layers are area- and depth-weighted SSURGO values (the basin is 82 % hydrologic soil group B), with van Genuchten parameters from Rosetta3. Overland-flow length, width and slope come from the terrain (Fig. 10).

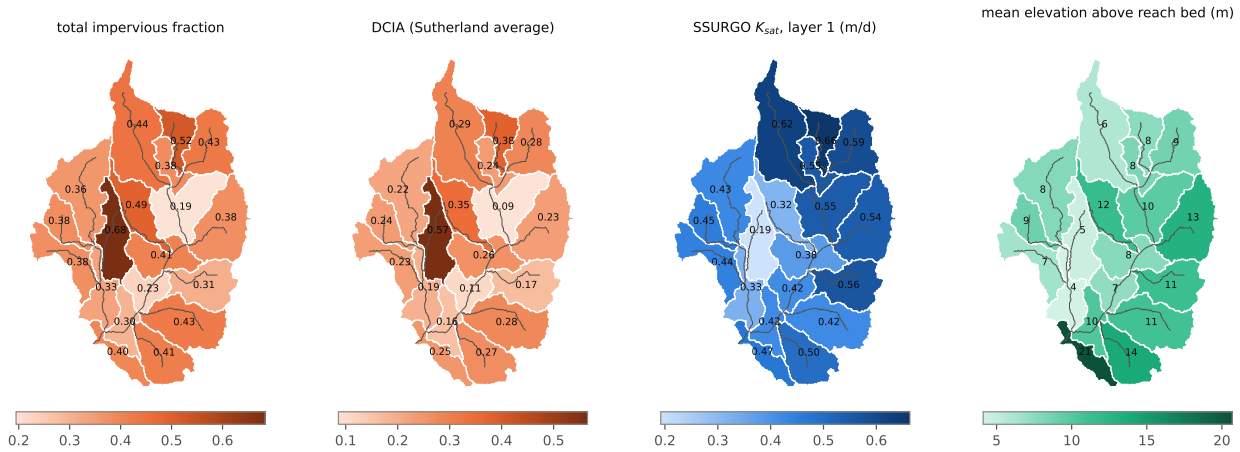


Figure 10: Total impervious fraction, connected impervious fraction, SSURGO saturated conductivity of the top soil layer and mean ground elevation above the stream bed, by sub-catchment.

Meteorological forcing. Rainfall and reference evapotranspiration are averaged over each sub-catchment with the overlap areas of the grid cells; mean annual AORC rainfall is about 1250 mm. The model was calibrated and validated with AORC rainfall; operationally it uses MRMS, multiplied by 1.08, the ratio of AORC to MRMS found over October 2024 to September 2025 for the surrounding Rock Creek watershed.

6 Calibration

Ten parameters were estimated, each applied identically to all 19 sub-catchments (Table 2), so that the differences between sub-catchments come entirely from the data above. They were fitted to discharge at the gage over water years 2022–2025 and to stage over 2024–2025 (the period of the current USGS rating), using hourly values during storms and daily values otherwise, after a two-month spin-up. The errors of the logarithms of flow and stage are modelled as autocorrelated (a first-order autoregressive process in continuous time) with standard deviations and correlation times that were estimated with the parameters.

The parameters were estimated by Bayesian inference: a genetic algorithm and the Levenberg–Marquardt method located the best fit, and an adaptive Markov chain Monte Carlo sampler (23 chains) then drew samples from the posterior distribution, starting from it. The sampler found a better region than the gradient method (the log-likelihood improved by about 530), mainly by dropping the large extra factor on the conductivity of the top soil layer (from 26 to 1.1). The twin runs the sample with the highest posterior probability; Table 2 gives it with the 95 % posterior range. The sampler had not fully converged when these sets were drawn; a longer run is in progress, and the twin's parameter sets will be updated with its result.

Table 2: Calibrated parameters: the twin's parameter set and the 2.5–97.5 % posterior range.

Parameter	Role	Twin	95 % range
Soil conductivity multiplier	scales SSURGO K_s of all layers	0.030	0.028–0.040
Surface conductivity multiplier	additional factor on the top layer	1.12	0.82–1.45
Connected-impervious multiplier	scales the Sutherland DCIA	0.38	0.37–0.46
Crop coefficient, top layer	K_c	0.48	0.26–0.64
Crop coefficient, deeper layers	K_{c2}	0.13	0.10–0.21
Aquifer–stream conductivity	K_b, m/d	347	151–356
Aquifer conductivity	K_g, m/d (lateral flow)	496	381–5930
Aquifer specific yield	S_y	0.0069	0.0052–0.0087
Channel roughness	Manning n, open channels	0.072	0.070–0.123
Sewer diameter multiplier	on the fitted sewer sizes	0.47	0.42–0.59
Flow error	s.d. of log flow; correlation time (d)	0.54; 0.12	
Stage error	s.d. of log stage; correlation time (d)	0.17; 0.13	

The soil conductivity multiplier is small: the calibration reduces the SSURGO conductivities about 30-fold, which lets the pervious surfaces produce runoff in large storms (SSURGO conductivities exceed most hourly rain rates). The connected-impervious multiplier means that about 10 % of the basin, rather than the 25 % from the Sutherland relation, sends its runoff directly to the streams and sewers, plausibly reflecting the stormwater facilities and disconnected roofs that the model does not represent individually. Some parameters reach or pass their prior bounds (aquifer conductivity, sewer multiplier); the priors are deliberately not truncated.

7 Fit and validation

The twin's parameter set was run continuously over the calibration period (WY2022–2025) and, unchanged, over WY2018–2021, which was not used in calibration (Tables 3 and 4 and Figs. 11 and 12). The logarithm of flow, which weights low flows and recessions, is reproduced with an NSE of 0.83 in both periods and stage with 0.78–0.80. The NSE of the flows themselves, dominated by the largest storms, is 0.62–0.66: storm peaks are about 30 % high on average and individual convective storms are missed or over-predicted, which is also the effect of the 1 km rainfall grid on a basin of this size. Low flows are 1.4–1.6 times the observed, the same tendency as in the Rock Creek model. The fit varies little between water years (log NSE 0.82–0.84).

Table 3: Fit of the twin's parameter set at USGS 01647850. The measures are computed on the observation points (hourly in storms, daily otherwise).

Period		NSE	logNSE	KGE	Volume	Low 20 %	High 20 %	n
Calibration WY2022–25	flow	0.62	0.83	0.58	1.27	1.58	1.32	9144
	stage	0.73	0.80	0.77				4808
Validation WY2018–21	flow	0.66	0.83	0.64	1.27	1.42	1.31	9558
	stage	0.66	0.78	0.71				4549

Table 4: Flow fit by water year (val.: validation, cal.: calibration).

Water year	2022	2023	2024	2025	2018	2019	2020	2021
Flow NSE	0.63	0.46	0.55	0.72	0.56	0.52	0.78	0.62
Flow logNSE	0.84	0.83	0.84	0.82	0.83	0.82	0.82	0.83
Period	cal.	cal.	cal.	cal.	val.	val.	val.	val.

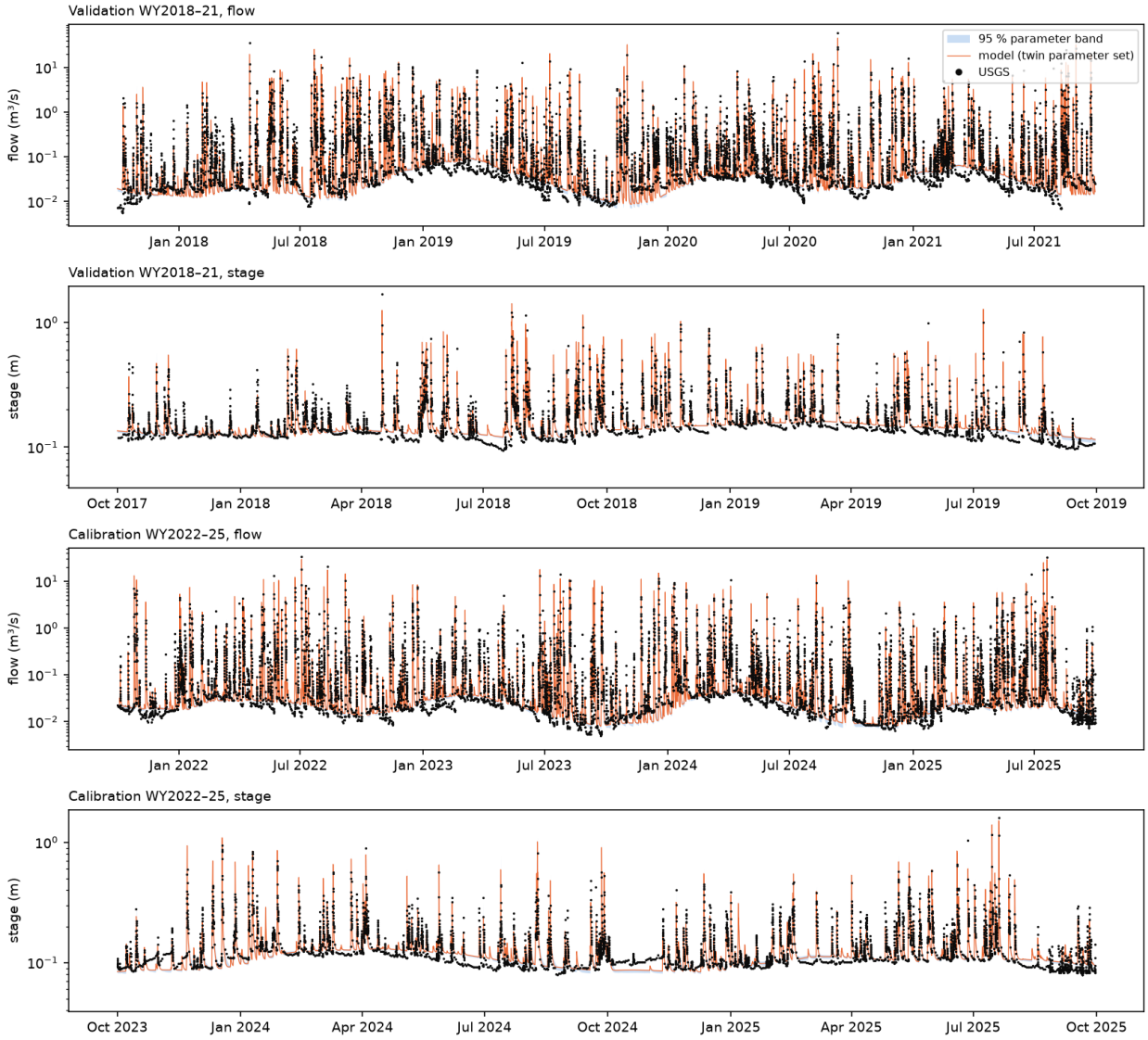


Figure 11: Validation (WY2018–21) and calibration (WY2022–25) periods: USGS (black), the twin's parameter set (orange) and the 95 % parameter band (blue), log scale.

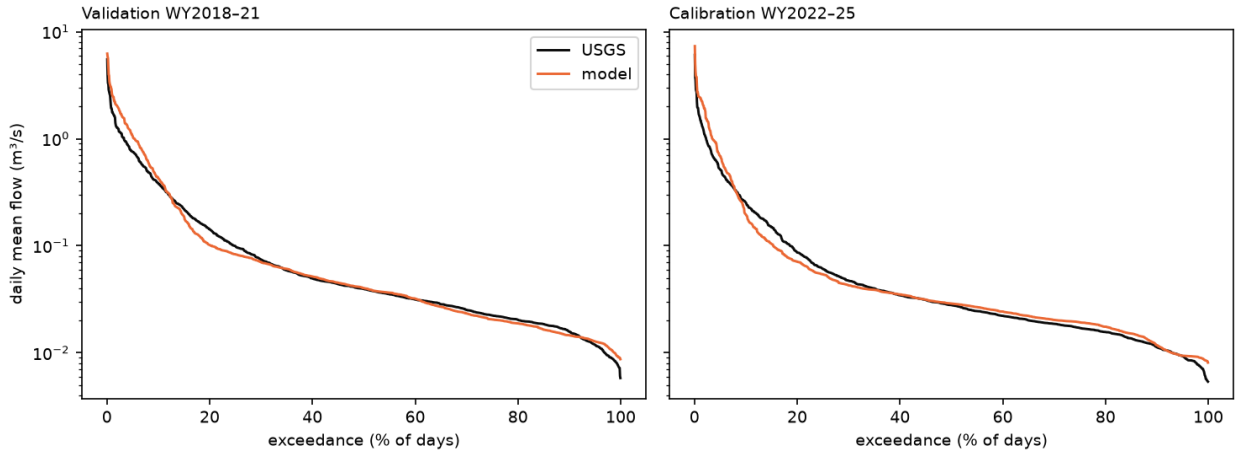


Figure 12: Flow-duration curves of the daily means of the observation points: USGS and the twin's parameter set.

Fit measures. NSE: Nash–Sutcliffe efficiency (1 is perfect, 0 is no better than the mean); logNSE: the same on the logarithms; KGE: Kling–Gupta efficiency, which combines correlation, variability and bias; volume: total model over observed; low/high 20 %: model over observed mean of the lowest/highest 20 % of the observed values.

7.1 Uncertainty

The 95 % band of the twin is the parameter uncertainty alone. It is narrow (on flow typically a factor of about 1.3 between its edges): the four years of data constrain the ten parameters well, so plausible parameter sets give similar results. The observations fall inside it only 13–19 % of the time, because most of the difference between model and data comes from the model structure and the rainfall, not from the parameters. A band that also includes these errors, estimated from the calibrated error model, contains 91–92 % of the observations in both periods but is much wider (a factor of about 7 on flow), wider than needed in dry weather and narrower than needed in storms. The twin shows the parameter band; forecast-rainfall uncertainty, the largest source of forecast error, is not yet represented.

8 Limitations

- **Low flows.** In dry weather the model keeps flow about 1.4–1.6 times the observed; low-flow stage is slightly high.
- **Storm peaks.** Peaks are on average about 30 % high, and the timing and size of individual convective storms depend on the radar rainfall over a basin covered by only a few 1 km cells.
- **Forecast rainfall** is the largest source of forecast error; the twin runs a single rainfall forecast and its band does not include rainfall uncertainty.
- **Simplifications.** Each piped unit's storm sewers are lumped into one sewer; small piped transfers across sub-catchment divides are neglected; only the three largest ponds are represented, with assumed outlets; bioretention and other small facilities are not represented individually.

- **No data assimilation** yet: the model state is not corrected with the real-time observations.

9 Software and reproducibility

The model is built and run with open-source software: OpenHydroQual (`https://github.com/ArashMassoudieh/OpenHydroQual`; Massoudieh et al., 2023; Massoudieh and Shakouri, 2025), the digital-twin engine OpenHydroTwin (`https://github.com/ArashMassoudieh/OHTwin`) and the watershed twin and viewer OpenWatershedTwin (`https://github.com/ArashMassoudieh/OpenWatershedTwin`). Every input file of the model is produced by numbered scripts from the public data listed in Table 1. The live twin is at `https://openhydrotwin.com/TurkeyBranch/`.

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